dyes like indigo, lac, and dhak. The artists used mainly the tempera method of applying paint to dried plaster. The murals in the Khwabgah, the Khizana-i *Anuptalao* and the Sonahra Makan (Maryam's House) glowed with narrative paintings including figures, angels, landscapes, elephants, cheetahs, and horses. While the figurative paintings were reserved for the more private spaces, the public spaces were decorated with flowers and trees including jasmine, marigold, champa, poppy, rose, and tulip. There would also have been masses of fragrant flowers in vases: chameli in the monsoon, mogra in the summer, nargis in the spring, and champa all year round. The court was kept scented with incense too, ambergris and aloe wood, using ancient recipes or new inventions. In the background, as the water channels were built, and the fountains installed, water quietly flowed, a consoling music as the heat soared.

During this maelstrom of activity in 1574, an elderly man was brought in chains from Ahmedabad to Fatehpur Sikri, to be interrogated by the Padshah and his ulema. This was the famous Mahdavi Shaikh Mustafa Gujarati whose family and dairah had been decimated, and who had already spent some months at Aziz Koka's court, being brutally questioned. Now Akbar, his noblemen, and the ulema sat in a circle and placed the shaikh in the centre. One of the Gujarati noblemen disdainfully commented on the unkempt aspect of the old man. 'Shame on you,' was Akbar's sharp rebuke, 'he is an elderly person and one should talk to him respectfully.' Akbar then asked the shaikh to clarify his stand on Mahdavism, explaining that 'the ulema and (religious guides) are very hostile to you…. It is because of the efforts of the ulema that you have fallen into this predicament. How far is your heart afflicted by this?' The shaikh explained his philosophy emphasizing the Sufi, mystical aspect of Mahdavism, veering away from a political role. In a long discussion lasting many days, Akbar seemed to be using the shaikh to subtly question and undermine the ulema themselves. 'We are fifty or sixty people here trying to corner the Shaikh by our questions,' the Padshah said. 'The Shaikh, despite his poverty, shackles, being away from his father or brother and relatives and friends, sits in our court as if he is our master. He is answering each and every one of our questions with dignity, aplomb and steadfastness.' During another session, while trying to explain his allegiance to the Mahdi, the shaikh asked Akbar who his spiritual guide was. Bowing his head in veneration and touching his ear lobes the Padshah said, 'I am the disciple of Hazrat Khwaja Moinuddin